



Retro Game Buyer's Cheat Sheet

Spot fake cartridges, choose the right Game Boy, and know the going rate before you buy.

WANTWATCHER FIELD GUIDE

Retro handheld edition

Market snapshot: 23 Sep 2026

THE 60-SECOND CART CHECK

Buy the cartridge, not the story

1 Match the exact release.

Compare region, product code, label art, shell colour and moulded logos with a verified copy. Replacement labels and shells exist, so no exterior clue is conclusive.

2 Tilt the label under light.

Original GBA Pokémon labels have metallic/gem-like effects and usually a small factory number pressed into the label. Flat colour, blurry type or crooked cuts warn of a fake.

3 Inspect the board.

Ask for a sharp back/PCB photo. Look for clean Nintendo markings and the correct board code. Black epoxy blobs, stray wires or messy solder point to a reproduction.

4 Use the Pokémon shortcuts.

Ruby, Sapphire and Emerald have translucent shells and a clock battery; FireRed and LeafGreen have no battery. Genuine GBA Pokémon boards show four gold rectangles at upper left on the back.

5 Test more than boot-up.

Save, power off and reload; test the clock and link features where relevant. A dead original battery needs repair, but does not prove a fake.

Best proof: open the cart with the correct bit and compare both PCB sides with a verified example. No clear photos on an expensive title? Pass.

MODEL PICKER

Choose by library and screen

MODEL	WHAT CHANGES	PLAYS
Game Boy DMG-01	Large grey shell; unlit monochrome screen; 4 AA.	GB
Pocket MGB-001	Smaller, sharper unlit screen; 2 AAA.	GB
Color CGB-001	Colour, still unlit; 2 AA.	GB + GBC
Advance AGB-001	Wide grip, shoulder buttons, unlit colour; 2 AA.	GB + GBC + GBA
SP AGS-001	Clamshell, rechargeable; dimmer front-lit screen.	GB + GBC + GBA
SP AGS-101	Brighter backlit screen; two brightness levels.	GB + GBC + GBA

Quick console price bands

DMG-01 / Pocket	CA\$65–100
Game Boy Color	CA\$85–110
Game Boy Advance	CA\$95–125
GBA SP AGS-001	CA\$120–160
GBA SP AGS-101	CA\$170–210

Check the rear model label. Shell colour does not prove AGS-101. Mods, special editions and condition can shift value. Game Boy Micro plays GBA carts only.

PRICE ANCHOR

Know the band before you message

Red / Blue / Yellow	CA\$70–90
Gold / Silver	CA\$75–85
Crystal	CA\$200–240
Ruby / Sapphire	CA\$120–140
FireRed / LeafGreen	CA\$145–165
Emerald	CA\$315–355

Loose, authentic North American carts; rounded from current PriceCharting USD market values at about 1 USD = 1.41 CAD. Before tax and shipping. Verify sold listings again on purchase day.

Red flags worth walking away from

- ❗ Price is dramatically below the current market band with no clear defect.
- ❗ Seller uses stock, cropped or low-resolution photos, or will not show the back/PCB.
- ❗ Multiple “rare” carts share the same spotless label and identical wear.
- ❗ Fresh label on a heavily worn shell, mismatched screws, or obvious re-shelling.
- ❗ “Repro,” “replacement,” “custom,” or “for display” is buried in the description.
- ❗ No test of saves/clock, no return path, or pressure to pay outside the platform.

Sources: ConsoleMods fake-cart guide · iMore Pokémon verification guide · market values: [Game Boy](#), [Game Boy Color](#), [Game Boy Advance](#) · FX reference: [USD/CAD](#).
Prices move; condition, region and completeness matter.

Find the good listings first.
[WantWatcher](#)